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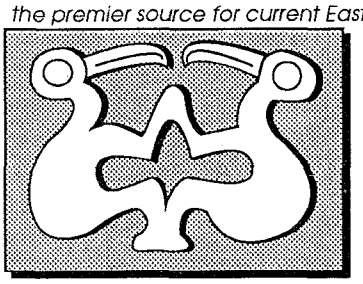

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WHAT'S NEW IN HANGAROA

Sit-down Strike at Mataveri Airport

Led by two outraged *rapanui* women who climbed over and then broke through the wire fence that runs along the side of the Mataveri airport runway, 30 women and children surrounded a LAN-Chile plane as it landed from Santiago. When the men saw that the "capture" was a success, they rode in on motorcycles and horses, and then everyone swarmed in to join them. It is estimated that 150 islanders plus assorted children, horses, dogs, and motorcycles eventually surrounded the LAN-Chile airplane. The runway was blocked and the scheduled flight was prevented from leaving the island for several days. It seems that LAN recently changed their policy that allowed islanders to travel to and from the continent at a reduced fare. Airfare had suddenly doubled at the same time that available seating for islanders was sharply curtailed, and a limit was placed on freight to Easter Island. The *rapanui* reacted in an attempt to get the attention of LAN Chile by a round-the-clock sit-in of the airstrip. In typical fashion, islanders played guitars and accordians, danced and partied, inviting stranded travellers to join the party. Children played soccer and rollerskated on the runway. Camping beneath the wings of the aircraft, islanders participating in the sit-in were brought food by others sympathetic to the cause; stores closed so their owners could participate and other merchants donated food. The next scheduled LAN flight sailed overhead, not stopping at the island. Following a weekend of negociations, the government agreed to temporarily subsidize the cost of flights until January to allow for time to settle the dispute between the islanders and the airline. One hour before the arrival of a Chilean army plane containing troops to 'restore order,' islanders simply melted away; when the plane landed, all was calm and back to normal.

An eyewitness stated that it seemed as if the entire village was out on the runway. Passengers and crew of the grounded airliner were accomodated at local hotels but were without luggage; brief interviews with passengers brought forth various comments, including some who wondered why this matter (of fares) had not been worked out earlier. Some French tourists were delighted with the stopover; an outraged North American kept threatening to sue the leaders of the strike; a few joined in with the strike. Two honeymooning couples said they were tired and just wanted to go to bed.

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Some Details From the Journal of Captain Bouman on the Discovery of Easter Island

Herbert von Saher

The editors of RNJ want more details from the journals on the discovery of Easter Island. In the Fall issue (1990), I gave details from the journal of Jacob Roggeveen, the commander of the Dutch fleet that discovered Easter Island on April 5th, 1722. That article provides a general outline of the purpose of the expedition and of the subsequent events.

We shall not repeat all that in this article, but shall concentrate on the journal of Captain Cornelis Bouman, captain of the ship *Thienhoven*, the second ship in the fleet under Roggeveen's command. Contrary to Roggeveen, who was exceptional because he was a doctor of law and an intellectual of a type that normally does not go on adventurous expeditions, Bouman was more the normal type of sailor with a much more limited education. But for us he has one advantage: Roggeveen kept the official journal of the expedition which logically is more restrained in style, with an obligatory entry for every day. Even on a day in the doldrums during which nothing happens, there is at least the weather report and a registration of the bearings made. Bouman feels much more free: on dull days he has no entry at all, but on days that arouse his interest, such as during the stay at Easter Island, his entries are much longer than those of Roggeveen. Bouman's journal is more a diary of a travel writer and he certainly does what Paul Fussell prescribes in his delightful book *Abroad, British Literary Travel between the Wars* (Oxford University Press, 1980): "The task of the travel writer is to spot the anomalies." Bouman has an eye for the "anomalies"; he is evidently amused by them and he makes note of them. That makes the task to read his journal a great pleasure.

Let us plunge immediately into his Easter Island adventure just as he does! His first confrontation can be described as no less than dramatic. We shall from time to time allow ourselves some comments between [ ].

April 7, Tuesday 1722. During the night variable winds with strong gusts, thunder and lightning [some weather report seems inevitable but please do not forget that it is the weather and specially the direction of the wind that dictates the movement of the ships but during the day the weather

continued on the following page

improved and we came somewhat nearer to the coast. Suddenly we became aware of a small boat near our ship in which an old naked man was sitting, shouting tremendously. I went to him in my sloop and I brought him, not withstanding much opposition, to the *Arent* [Roggeveen's ship; see also Roggeveen's entry of 7 April in the Fall RNJ]. He was a man, deep in his fifties, with dark skin, a goatee in the Turkish manner and of very strong bearing. He was greatly surprised by the construction of our ship and all that was on it, as we understood by his gestures. As we could not understand him in the least, we just had to interpret his gestures. We gave him a small mirror and when he saw himself, it frightened the wits out of him, as did the sounding of our bell. We gave him a small glass of Dutch gin which he poured over his mug and when he felt the force of it he started to rub his eyes. Then we gave him a second glass of gin and a small bisquit but he did not take any of it. He felt ashamed because of his nakedness as he saw that we were all dressed. Therefore he put his arms and head on the table and it seemed he addressed his gods about this, as we could clearly see from his movements: he raised his head and hands many times toward heaven, and used many words in a loud voice. He was busy in this way for about a half an hour, then he started jumping and singing and appeared very happy and gay. We bound a small piece of sailcloth in front of his private parts, which seemed to please him particularly. He had a very gay face. Then we ordered the violin to be played for him and he danced together with the sailors. He was greatly surprised by the music as well as the construction of the instrument.

His little boat was made of small narrow pieces of wood that were glued together with some organic material and on the inside there were two wooden ribs. It was so light that one man could easily carry it. For us it was a great surprise to see that a man alone dared to go out so far in the sea in such a tiny little boat with nothing at his disposition but one paddle, because when he reached us we were three sea miles from the coast.

In the afternoon we had the middle of the island at 2 miles south/southwest, and as the wind increased again and rain started we were forced to increase our distance from the coast so we had to take leave of our companion. He showed little inclination to leave. In order to get rid of him we had him brought to his boat but he kept paddling next to our ships until he saw that we were moving away from the coast. Only then did he return to the island. There was already a hollow sea and I was afraid that he would not make it.

[And with this note of consideration and care ended the first confrontation ever between an Easter Islander and Europeans. One could only wish that all the following ones had been as peaceful, friendly and musical as this one. But three days later, things began to go wrong.]

8 April, Wednesday. At two in the morning we turned southwest and at daybreak we were very near the northwest corner of the island, then we turned eastward. On land we saw several high statues in the heathen fashion as well as a great number of people. We tacked up to the coast and at eleven we were so near the coast in the middle of the island that we dropped anchor at 23 fathoms. The soil was greyish white sand with coral. Here we had the northern corner of the island straight east and the northwestern corner west/northwest and a high erected monolith that is near the coast southwest to west, these two corners forming a small bay where many inhabitants were standing. [Author's note: if we interpret this orientation literally it is impossible to be at sea in this position; the trouble with Easter Island is that its northwestern corner is also its northernmost point. But if we interpret this more freely then it can make sense: if the "northern corner" is the Poike peninsula (which is not the northern corner but the eastern one) which Bouman saw to the east, this should in fact be more east/southeast, Roggeveen gives the correct bearing in his journal and if the "northwestern corner" is Ana Nga Heu (to be found on the map on page V of the Uncommon Guide to Easter Island, which is in fact the northernmost point) and Bouman saw that to the west/northwest, if he anchors in a bay with white sandy soil and sees a big *moai* southwest to west, then that bay can only be Anakena, which is quite a dicovery!]

Then the commander ordered me to send a sloop to the coast for orientation with orders not to land if there were too many people about, epecially if they were armed. They were not armed but it was reported that there were many people about who immediately entered the water when the sloop neared land and made off with its oars. So the sloop returned to the ship without success, reporting that the natives were not all naked but were wearing white and yellow dresses as I had already noted from a distance while tacking. But the natives were not afraid of us at all; they came in small canoes and many came swimming on bundles of tied reeds [but not on reed rafts or in reed boats, of which Mr. Heyerdahl please take note]. They boarded our ships without any weapons and the sailors who had been on the beach earlier also confirmed that they had seen no weapons at all. They brought in their canoes or reed bundles both living and roasted chickens and bananas for which they asked nothing.

All looked with great surprise at our ship with its rigging but nevertheless they were big thieves, taking everything that they could lay their hands on. Some took worn brooms, broken spokes, firewood and such things, and jumped overboard with them and swam to the coast. I think that they did this more out of curiosity than to have any benefit from these absolutely worthless objects. Towards the evening we made them swim back; those that had boats paddled back to the coast because we had become weary of their company. It was then decided to go on land with a big landing party next day.

9 April, Thursday. Very beautiful weather, little wind. We used this quiet day to careen the ship for cleaning the underside. A lot of people came on board again, swimming as well as in boats, and brought chickens, yams and bananas but we did not allow too many on board.

I went on board with the commander to prepare everything for the landing party. I put an officer for every three men under my command, a total of 23 persons including the surgeon and the ensign, a corporal and 18 soldiers and 8 more sailors who would also be armed to guard the sloop when we went on shore. During the night we had a sweet little land-wind. [Even the weather report can be poetic sometimes].

10 April, Friday. In the morning, quiet pleasant weather; at seven we went to shore with 5 sloops in order to land. Our party totaled 52 men, sailors as well as soldiers; from the *Arent* 68; and from the *Africaanse Galley* 17 men, so that our total strength was 134 [calculating error] from our three ships. We came on land without difficulty, that is to say except those who had been ordered to stay in the sloops to guard them. The inhabitants carried no weapons of any kind, but came to welcome us in masses with their bare hands, hopping and jumping for joy.

Notwithstanding this, 9 or 10 of them were shot at and killed by our men and some wounded for which my officer Cornelis Mens was responsible. He fired without any order from the commander, which led other men to the conclusion that an order had been given so they also opened fire. It was taken very ill of him. Later he excused himself saying that the inhabitants had tried to steal his gun and had threatened to throw stones. This was not believed by Mr. Roggeveen, Captains Coster and Roosendaal, the lieutenant, my ensign nor any sailors who had been present because we landed first and passed through a great number of inhabitants who made room for us, showing great friendliness. The officer maintained that he had been assaulted, but all other officers were of the opinion that he had acted out of cowardice. When we landed he had been difficult because, as second of my company, he should have landed immediately after me; however, he remained in the sloop up to the last and then chose another way to go on land where he saw fewer people and that is where he started firing.

After this had happened the inhabitants fled from the beach. We then marched to their dwellings in which we found absolutely nothing. These dwellings are built of a sort of straw looking like beehives or as if a Greenland sloop has been turned upside down. The entrances are extremely low so that one has to creep in and out on hands and knees. These entrances are all directed toward the northeast so that the inhabitants, coming out in the morning, can honour and serve their god in this way, because all the openings correspond accordingly. [It takes a sailor to notice this but whether this uniform direction has a religious background or that it is indicated to be away from the strong prevailing winds, is another matter]. We stopped our force there.

In the meantime we saw the inhabitants flying into the mountains, but we had no intention of following them because we saw nothing of value on this island. When we prepared to return to the beach, an inhabitant approached us quietly, wearing a crown of white feathers on his head, a white dress and a white shell hanging on his breast. Even when still walking he showed homage by stooping. He laid a bunch of bananas down on the ground at least thirty steps from us and then galloped away like a horse. But when he saw that this was agreeable to us, he returned together with other inhabitants, bringing more chickens, bananas and young plants. They again laid them down together with sugarcane. We only took the chickens and the bananas. This Indian with the feathers was one of their chiefs as is shown by the following incident. When he ordered others to do something which they did not do, he took a stone and threatened to throw it at the unwilling person, whereupon that person immediately went on his knees with folded hands and laid down to bid his mercy, which was granted. Then the other rose and executed what he had been ordered to do. While we walked back this chief made others bring us more chickens and bananas but they were not very well provided with these, and we could clearly notice from their fear that they would have brought more if they had had more. As we saw that they were so poor, we compensated them with half a piece of Haarlem cloth of 5 to 6 penny per yard [apparently of some value], which they accepted with gratitude. We were accompanied to the beach by some of the chiefs where we stayed until everyone was on board. So we left like good friends.

The share of our ship in the total quantity acquired during this tour on land was 18 chickens, big as well as small, and 13 small unripe bunches of bananas. The *Arent* and the *Affricaanse Galley* received their portion proportional to the number of men on board.

In the meantime a strong northerly wind had started and we would have sailed immediately when everyone was back on board but in neither direction could we sail above the corners of the bay, so we were forced to remain there. [This proves that their anchor site was Anakena Bay. With a northerly wind you can still escape under sail eastward from La Perouse Bay but not from Anakena]. During the night there was a strong wind, and for security's sake we lowered the yards and brought out a sheet-anchor.

The island has gently sloping mountains like one sees in England. The inhabitants have clearly divided their arable land in square fields with furrows. They have planted these with yams and other crops that I do not know. Also with sugarcane that is thick, long, and has long members; yes, much heavier than I have seen in Surinam, Curacao, the coast of Venezuela, Martinique, Brazil or anywhere else. The juice of this cane was very sweet. Of yams, bananas, and small coconut palms we saw little and no other trees or crops. The population grows only these crops. They have only a small number of chickens and no other fowl or cattle. They managed to prepare the chickens very nicely in holes in the ground in which they had stones that were heated glowing hot by burning bushes. The chickens were then bound in wide-leafed grass and put on the hot stones and were covered with dry leaves. In this way the chickens were ready in a very short time and those of us who ate them declared *continued on the following page*

Bouman continued....

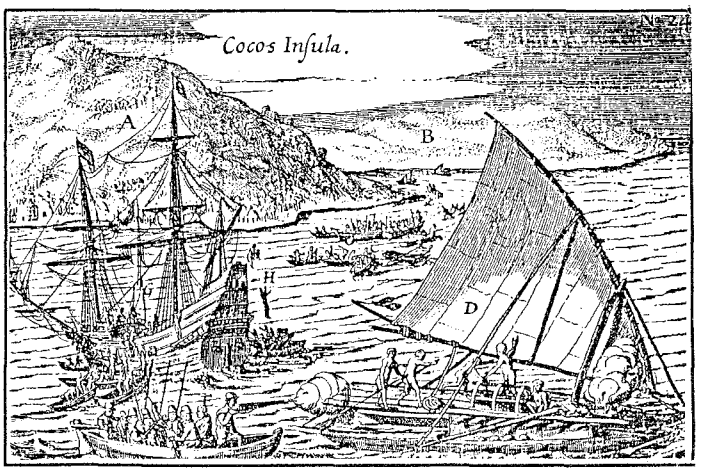
that they tasted very well and that the meat was well done. Their clothes consist of white or yellow cloth that they rub with some red earth from the soil. It is neither wool nor cotton, neither grass, hemp or flax; it was not woven nor spun. It seemed to be worked together with warm water. The junction was strange in our eyes. In my opinion this clothing material must be a wool or hairiness that one finds in the heart of the yam, and that they know how to prepare in some way or another. On their mountains we saw from a distance some white material lying there to bleach. [Bouman's description is completely clear and correct but evidently he was not acquainted with textiles made from beaten treebark, a material widely used in Polynesia because wool was non-existant there where as cotton was available, for instance, on Tahiti. But the Polynesians did not know that it can be spun and woven. That is another proof that the Incas, who were then certainly the worlds' greatest experts in spinning and weaving cotton have never come there to teach this to the Polynesians, of which Mr. Heyerdahl please take note.]

We found no furniture at all and of utensils, only calabashes in which they keep their water. I tasted it and found it to be very brackish. They know no steel, iron or other minerals, nor weapons or any objects that we showed to them such as scissors, needles, coral [beads], mirrors and such things. They did not know either what you can do with a knife before we showed them. They cut their bananas with a sharp little black stone [obsidian]. They first cut around the branch and then twist it off. From all this I conclude that they have never seen other people than those who live on this island.

We gave this island the name Easter Island because we discovered it on first Easterday. [For the American reader, in northern Europe we have first and second Easterday, that is itself a remnant from heathen Germanic spring rituals which Christianity probably reluctantly adopted.]

Here Captain Bouman interrupts his diary and then jumps to 18 May, five weeks later when the Dutch fleet had left Easter Island far behind. When one looks back on this journal and that of Commander Roggeveen it is really surprising to see that their stay near Easter Island was so short--less than one week with the island in sight and less than one whole day on shore. No wonder that the impressions are only of the most superficial sort and moreover these visitors were not anthropologists. Nevertheless, their observations give us some understanding of how the situtation was on Easter Island in 1722.

In a following article we shall give more detailed impressions from another diary about a longer visit made some fifty years later.



Engraving from the journal of Jacob le Maire, 1616. Although historically earlier, it gives an idea of how Roggeveen's landing on Easter Island might have looked

Sit-down *.....continued from page 49*

Islanders partying at sit-in on Mataveri runway; the sign reads "LAN, Basta de abusos".

One of the stranded travellers was British journalist Nick Cater who continued to telephone to the BBC in London as the sit-in developed. This probably was the first direct broadcast from Rapa Nui that has enjoyed world coverage. The BBC continued to report about the situation in hourly news broadcasts all day on the 25th of November. It was fortuitous for the protesting Rapanui as the consequences of their blocking the runway were shared by tens of millions throughout the world. A follow-up on the story was broadcast two days later reporting on the cessation of the sit-in and news that a Rapanui delegation would be sent to Santiago for negociations.